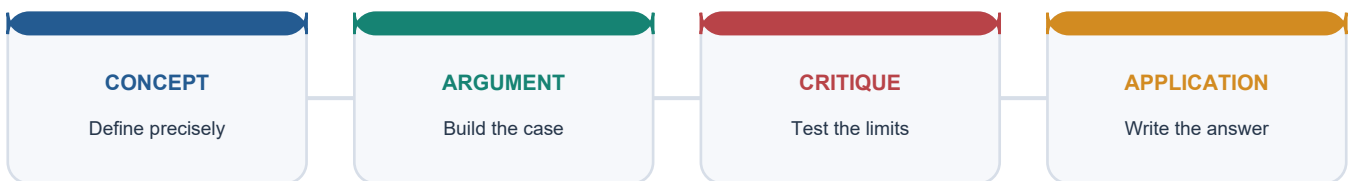


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Harappan Civilization: Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Harappan Civilization: Complete Learning Session

Subject: Ancient History | **Paper:** Prelims GS-I with GS-I Mains architecture support | **Level:** Core first; Optional Advanced separately labelled **Source order:** canonical Core owner; labelled Advanced owner; official syllabus and routed PYQ record; OCR-searchable R.S. Sharma and Upinder Singh. Static archaeological coverage was sufficient; no live claim was needed. **Evidence rule:** distinguish excavated observation, contextual inference and unresolved interpretation. No fabricated date, site feature, decipherment, deity, state form or genetic identity is used.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

COVERAGE AND CONTROL LEDGER

Required dimension	Sessions
Terminology, origin, phases, discovery and historiography	1-2
Extent, mapping, settlement hierarchy, labour and urban-rural relation	3-4
Planning, drainage and precise major-site evidence	5-10
Subsistence, craft, metallurgy, ceramics, art, measures and exchange	11-14
Script, polity, society, burial, religion and inference limits	15-18
Religion, rivers, decline, Late continuity, science, comparison and legacy	19-21

ORIGIN AND TIMELINE RAIL

7th millennium BCE onward: north-western farming antecedents; not a direct one-line city sequence

c. 3300-2600 BCE: Early Harappan regionalisation and proto-urban growth

c. 2600-1900 BCE: Mature Harappan urban integration

c. 1900-1300 BCE: Late Harappan localisation/deurbanisation, varying regionally

Chronology caution: use these as broad archaeological ranges. Site phases and calibrated dates may begin or end differently.

PROGRESSIVE ROADMAP

1. Establish the evidence grammar and phased chronology.
2. Map the ecological and settlement system.
3. Lock major sites to precise features and cautions.
4. Reconstruct subsistence, craft, measurement and trade.
5. Separate secure evidence from polity, society and religion hypotheses.
6. Explain decline as regional transformation and use science within sample limits.

SESSION 1 - TERMINOLOGY, ORIGINS AND THE EARLY-MATURE-LATE CHRONOLOGY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The Harappan or Indus civilisation was a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation whose wide distribution and undeciphered script require phase-based, regionally qualified reconstruction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Use regionalisation -> integration -> localisation, not a sudden rise-and-fall story.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Harappan

- Indus civilisation
- Early-Mature-Late
- regionalisation
- integration
- localisation

VISUAL FIRST

REGIONAL FOOD-PRODUCING CULTURES

↓
Early Harappan: c. 3300-2600 BCE

↓
Mature urban integration: c. 2600-1900 BCE

↓
Late localisation/deurbanisation: c. 1900-1300 BCE, varying regionally

CORE TEACHING

"Harappan" is usually the safer archaeological term because settlements extended far beyond the Indus valley. The roots lay in earlier north-western farming and regional cultures, but no single village or migration explains urbanisation. Dates are broad working ranges: beginnings and endings vary by site, calibration and scholarly convention.

Phase	Broad dates	Historical process	Diagnostic tendency
Early Harappan	c. 3300-2600 BCE	Regionalisation and proto-urban growth	Fortified/planned settlements, regional pottery, craft and exchange
Mature Harappan	c. 2600-1900 BCE	Urban integration	Cities, common sign system, seals, standard weights, brick norms and wide exchange
Late Harappan	c. 1900-1300 BCE, varying regionally	Localisation and deurbanisation	Reduced urban traits, settlement shifts, regional pottery and diversified agriculture

regional food-producing cultures
↓ interaction, craft and settlement growth
Early Harappan regionalisation
↓ intensified coordination
Mature Harappan integration
↓ regionally varied transformation
Late Harappan localisation

ANALYSIS: These are archaeological process phases, not three sealed peoples. Beginnings and endings vary by site and region.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Early fortified and planned settlements such as Kot Diji, Rehman Dheri and Kalibangan I show that craft, exchange and settlement hierarchy preceded Mature integration.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan urbanism developed from regional antecedents rather than appearing fully formed. Early fortified settlements such as Kot Diji and Kalibangan I already display planning, craft and exchange before the Mature phase. Their convergence helps explain the later spread of seals, weights, writing and brick norms. Yet the phase boundaries remain archaeological tools, not dates when one population suddenly replaced another.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Do not equate Early, Mature and Late phases with three separate peoples or fixed subcontinental dates.
- **Correct control:** Use regionalisation -> integration -> localisation, not a sudden rise-and-fall story.

MAINS USE

Open an origin or decline answer with the process sequence and qualify dates by site and region.

MINI RECAP

Phase labels describe changing systems; they do not name races.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

TERMINOLOGY, ORIGINS AND THE EARLY-MATURE-LATE CHRONOLOGY

-> KEYWORDS: Harappan | Indus civilisation | Early-Mature-Late | regionalisation | integration | localisation

-> ANSWER LINE: Use regionalisation -> integration -> localisation, not a sudden rise-and-fall story.

-> RECAP: Phase labels describe changing systems; they do not name races.

SESSION 2 - DISCOVERY, EXCAVATION AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan historiography is the changing interpretation of an archaeological record whose contexts and methods have expanded since the first excavations.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The discovery history moved from spectacular monuments and invasion stories toward regional, household and scientific archaeology.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Cunningham
- Daya Ram Sahni
- R. D. Banerji
- John Marshall
- Wheeler
- context

VISUAL FIRST

1853 seal noticed -> 1921 Harappa excavation -> 1920s Mohenjo-daro/announcement

-> city-centred interpretations -> household, landscape and scientific archaeology

CORE TEACHING

Date/phase	Development	Caution
1853	Alexander Cunningham noticed a Harappan seal	Its civilizational significance was not recognised
1921	Daya Ram Sahni began excavation at Harappa	"Harappan" derives from the first excavated type-site
1920s	R.D. Banerji worked at Mohenjo-daro; John Marshall announced the civilisation	Early interpretations reflected limited excavation and comparison
Later research	Expanded to villages, households, crafts, plants, animals, human remains and landscapes	Functional labels and social models remain revisable

Because the script remains undeciphered, Harappan history is reconstructed primarily from archaeology. Material evidence is strongest for construction, production, diet, exchange and settlement; it is weaker for named rulers, language, doctrine, law and personal belief.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Daya Ram Sahni's 1921 Harappa excavation and R. D. Banerji's Mohenjo-daro work enabled John Marshall to announce the civilisation; later research widened the evidentiary field.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The Harappan civilisation was recognised through cumulative archaeological work, not through a recovered native chronicle. Sahni at Harappa and Banerji at Mohenjo-daro supplied the contexts that Marshall publicised, while later surveys and laboratory methods shifted attention to villages, food, craft and environment. This enlarged the questions historians can ask. It also exposes the limits of early functional labels created from incomplete excavation records.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** An excavator's first label is a hypothesis, not proof of a building's function or a deity's identity.

- **Correct control:** The discovery history moved from spectacular monuments and invasion stories toward regional, household and scientific archaeology.

MAINS USE

Use historiography to show how interpretations of polity, religion and decline changed with evidence.

MINI RECAP

Better methods refine inference; they do not magically decipher the civilisation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

DISCOVERY, EXCAVATION AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

-> KEYWORDS: Cunningham | Daya Ram Sahni | R. D. Banerji | John Marshall | Wheeler | context

-> ANSWER LINE: The discovery history moved from spectacular monuments and invasion stories toward regional, household and scientific archaeology.

-> RECAP: Better methods refine inference; they do not magically decipher the civilisation.

SESSION 3 - GEOGRAPHICAL SPREAD, SITE MAPPING AND THE GHAGGAR-HAKRA QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan space was a vast multi-ecological network across river plains, highland routes, semi-arid zones and coasts.

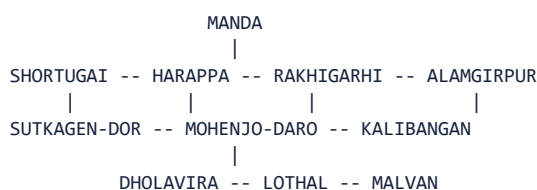
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Map the civilisation by ecological domains and phase, not by one rigid boundary or one river name.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Sutkagen-dor
- Manda
- Alamgirpur
- Malvan
- Shortugai
- Ghaggar-Hakra

VISUAL FIRST



CORE TEACHING

"Harappan" is safer than "Indus Valley" because the distribution extended far beyond the Indus valley.

Direction/domain	Representative evidence
West	Sutkagen-dor on the Makran coast
North-west outpost	Shortugai in Afghanistan near highland mineral routes
North	Manda in the Jammu region
East	Alamgirpur in western Uttar Pradesh
South	Malvan in southern Gujarat; Daimabad preserves southern Late-Harappan/contact evidence but should not be used mechanically as the Mature-phase extreme
Indus core	Harappa, Mohenjo-daro and many Sindh/Punjab settlements

Direction/domain	Representative evidence
Ghaggar-Hakra/Haryana-Rajasthan	Kalibangan, Banawali, Rakhigarhi and dense settlement zones
Kutch/Saurashtra/Gujarat	Dholavira, Lothal, Surkotada, Desalpur, Rangpur and coastal/resource sites

ANALYSIS: Extent estimates vary with survey intensity, site definition and chronological phase. Use "vast multi-ecological distribution" rather than one immutable area number.

ANALYSIS: The Ghaggar-Hakra palaeochannel and the textual Sarasvati are related but distinct research questions; physical course, site chronology and textual identification require separate evidence.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

The conventional extremes and the Afghanistan outpost demonstrate a distribution crossing the Indus, Ghaggar-Hakra, Gujarat coast and highland procurement routes.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The term Indus Valley can mislead when treated literally. Sites from Sutkagen-dor to Alamgirpur and from Manda to southern Gujarat show a civilisation spanning several drainage and ecological zones, while Shortugai marks a distant route node. This spread explains regional differences in crops, water and architecture. It does not justify fixing every mapped site in the same phase or equating the Ghaggar-Hakra palaeochannel automatically with the Vedic Sarasvati.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Keep palaeochannel reconstruction, settlement chronology and textual Sarasvati identification as separate propositions.
- **Correct control:** Map the civilisation by ecological domains and phase, not by one rigid boundary or one river name.

MAINS USE

Use a west-north-east-south map sentence, then explain ecological adaptation and survey limits.

MINI RECAP

Wide distribution, phased occupation and contested river nomenclature must be stated together.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

GEOGRAPHICAL SPREAD, SITE MAPPING AND THE GHAGGAR-HAKRA QUESTION

- > KEYWORDS: Sutkagen-dor | Manda | Alamgirpur | Malvan | Shortugai | Ghaggar-Hakra
- > ANSWER LINE: Map the civilisation by ecological domains and phase, not by one rigid boundary or one river name.
- > RECAP: Wide distribution, phased occupation and contested river nomenclature must be stated together.

SESSION 4 - SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY, LABOUR AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan urbanism was a hierarchy of cities, towns, specialist centres, villages, pastoral spaces and resource nodes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cities were coordinating nodes in a rural and resource-dependent system, not isolated monuments.

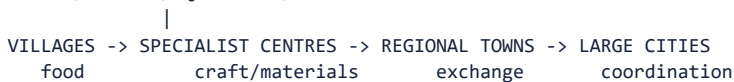
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **settlement hierarchy**
- **urban-rural relation**
- **specialist centre**
- **surplus**
- **labour**

- resource node

VISUAL FIRST

FARMS / HERDS / QUARRIES / COASTS



CORE TEACHING

Settlement role	Examples	Function
Large cities	Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Rakhigarhi, Ganweriwala	Dense residence, administration/coordination, craft, consumption and public works
Regional centres	Kalibangan, Banawali and other fortified towns	Agricultural-craft exchange and regional coordination
Specialist centres	Chanhudaro, Nageshwar, Lothal craft zones	Beads, shell, seals, metallurgy and other production
Villages/farmsteads	Numerous small settlements; Allahdino as a small wealthy example	Food, livestock and local production
Outposts/resource nodes	Shortugai and coastal/quarry sites	Raw-material procurement and route control

ANALYSIS: An urban civilisation does not mean every settlement was a city. Large centres depended on rural producers, pastoralists, specialists and routes.

ANALYSIS: Standardisation implies coordination, not automatically one centralised empire.

Labour was required for brick-making, construction, drain cleaning, reservoir maintenance, craft production, transport and food provisioning. Archaeology can identify tasks and concentrations of work more securely than the legal status of workers.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Chanhudaro's craft concentration, Shortugai's route position and large cities such as Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira and Rakhigarhi reveal functional differentiation.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan cities depended on a wider productive landscape. Chanhudaro concentrated craft, Shortugai connected mineral routes, and numerous villages supplied food and animals to larger centres. Such differentiation implies organised labour and exchange across settlement levels. It does not reveal whether workers were household producers, attached specialists, seasonal labourers or state dependants in every context.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Urban civilisation does not mean most settlements were cities or that all labour was centrally commanded.
- **Correct control:** Cities were coordinating nodes in a rural and resource-dependent system, not isolated monuments.

MAINS USE

Link urban form to food, materials, labour and routes before discussing authority.

MINI RECAP

Urban splendour rested on rural production and specialised work.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY, LABOUR AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM

-> KEYWORDS: settlement hierarchy | urban-rural relation | specialist centre | surplus | labour | resource node

-> ANSWER LINE: Cities were coordinating nodes in a rural and resource-dependent system, not isolated monuments.

-> RECAP: Urban splendour rested on rural production and specialised work.

SESSION 5 - TOWN PLANNING, HOUSE FORM AND REGIONAL VARIATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan planning combined recurring construction norms with substantial site-specific layouts and materials.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Standardisation created a shared urban grammar, not one identical city plan.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- 1:2:4 brick ratio
- courtyard house
- street alignment
- raised sector
- mud brick
- regional adaptation

VISUAL FIRST

SHARED GRAMMAR

brick modules + streets + courtyards + controlled access

Mohenjo-daro/Harappa	Dholavira/Kalibangan/Banawali
baked-brick water focus	stone/local plans and variants

CORE TEACHING

Common tendencies

- planned streets and lanes, though not one perfect grid everywhere;
- courtyards, bathing floors, drains and wells in many houses;
- mud brick as a basic material and baked brick concentrated in water/public structures at several sites;
- commonly used Mature-phase brick proportions near 1:2:4;
- raised/enclosed sectors, fortifications or platforms;
- differentiated house sizes and craft areas.

Citadel/lower-town caution

"Citadel" and "lower town" are archaeological spatial labels. A raised or fortified sector does not by itself prove a palace, priestly residence or ruling-class quarter.

Site	Architectural signature	Interpretive caution
Harappa	Multiple mounds, working platforms, cemetery and 12-unit building	"Granary" remains a conventional functional label
Mohenjo-daro	Great Bath, wells, drains, courtyard houses and public structures	"Priest-king", "college", "assembly hall" and "granary" are modern labels
Dholavira	Stone construction, multiple enclosed sectors, reservoirs and signboard	Corrects a universal two-part city model; "stadium" is interpretive

Site	Architectural signature	Interpretive caution
Kalibangan	Fortified sectors, early ploughed field and fire installations	Drainage differed from Mohenjo-daro; fire does not prove Vedic ritual
Lothal	Brick basin, craft workshops, drains and measurement evidence	"Dockyard" is a leading but archaeological interpretation
Banawali	Curved/fortified planning, moat, houses with seals/weights and plough model	Elite activity was not confined automatically to a "citadel"
Chanhudaro	Unfortified specialist craft town	Urban production without a conventional citadel

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Courtyard houses and recurring brick proportions coexist with Dholavira's stone-and-multi-sector plan, Kalibangan's different drainage and Chanhudaro's unfortified craft form.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The strongest architectural claim is coordinated diversity. Mature brick proportions, courtyard houses and ordered streets show widely shared technical norms, while Dholavira's stone construction and multi-part plan depart from a simple citadel-lower-town template. Regional builders adapted common practices to materials, water and settlement function. Therefore planning indicates communication and institutional capacity, but neither complete uniformity nor a known imperial building code.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** A raised 'citadel' is an archaeological spatial label, not automatic proof of a royal palace.
- **Correct control:** Standardisation created a shared urban grammar, not one identical city plan.

MAINS USE

Structure an architecture answer as shared norms -> named regional variants -> function-label caution.

MINI RECAP

One civilisation, several urban solutions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

TOWN PLANNING, HOUSE FORM AND REGIONAL VARIATION

-> KEYWORDS: 1:2:4 brick ratio | courtyard house | street alignment | raised sector | mud brick | regional adaptation

-> ANSWER LINE: Standardisation created a shared urban grammar, not one identical city plan.

-> RECAP: One civilisation, several urban solutions.

SESSION 6 - WATER, DRAINAGE AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan water systems joined household facilities, street drainage and site-specific storage or flood-management works.

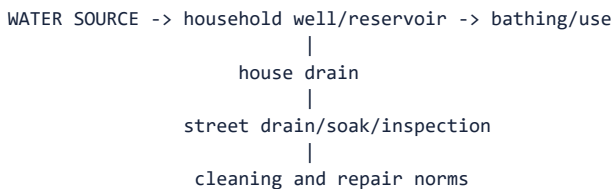
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Water architecture proves repeated technical coordination more securely than it proves a particular government.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- bathing floor
- covered drain
- soak jar
- well
- reservoir
- maintenance

VISUAL FIRST



CORE TEACHING

Secure evidence

- house bathing floors linked to street drains at several sites;
- covered drains, soak jars/pits and inspection arrangements;
- public/private/neighbourhood wells, especially at Mohenjo-daro;
- the Great Bath's baked brick, gypsum mortar and bitumen waterproofing;
- Dholavira's dams, channels, cisterns and reservoir system between seasonal streams;
- site-specific flood control, platforms and water storage.

ANALYSIS: Drains required cleaning, repair and collective norms; architecture therefore supports organised civic maintenance. It does not reveal the constitutional form of government.

ANALYSIS: Harappan sanitation was sophisticated but not uniform. Kalibangan, Dholavira, Lothal and Mohenjo-daro used different water/drainage solutions.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Mohenjo-daro's wells and drains, the Great Bath's waterproofing and Dholavira's dams, channels and reservoirs show several scales of water engineering.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan sanitation was an operating system rather than a decorative feature. At Mohenjo-daro, wells, bathing floors and street drains linked private use to shared infrastructure, while Dholavira channelled seasonal water into storage. These arrangements required design, cleaning and recurring labour. They support civic coordination, but archaeology does not disclose whether a monarch, council, neighbourhood group or another institution directed maintenance.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Do not universalise Mohenjo-daro's drain pattern to every site or infer a named municipal office.
- **Correct control:** Water architecture proves repeated technical coordination more securely than it proves a particular government.

MAINS USE

Turn drains into an argument about maintenance, labour and regional adaptation.

MINI RECAP

Observe the system; qualify the institution.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

WATER, DRAINAGE AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

- > KEYWORDS: bathing floor | covered drain | soak jar | well | reservoir | maintenance
- > ANSWER LINE: Water architecture proves repeated technical coordination more securely than it proves a particular government.
- > RECAP: Observe the system; qualify the institution.

SESSION 7 - SITE PRECISION I: HARAPPA AND MOHENJO-DARO

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The two best-known cities share Mature Harappan norms but preserve different evidence for production, burial, water and public form.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Pair Harappa's production-mortuary evidence with Mohenjo-daro's water-built landscape.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Ravi
- Cemetery R-37
- working platforms
- Great Bath
- wells
- Dancing Girl

VISUAL FIRST

HARAPPA	MOHENJO-DARO
Ravi/type-site	Indus/Sindh
R-37 + working platforms	Great Bath + wells/drains
12-unit 'granary' caution	'Priest-King' label caution

CORE TEACHING

Site	Secure evidence	What it supports	Required caution
Harappa	Ravi-region type-site; multiple mounds; Cemetery R-37; craft areas; circular working platforms; seals and weights; a 12-unit building	Long urban sequence, production, mortuary evidence and coordination	The 12-unit building is conventionally called a "granary"; its exact institutional function is not textually known
Mohenjo-daro	Great Bath; numerous wells; courtyard houses; bathing floors and drains; workshops; bronze "Dancing Girl"; stone male bust	Civic engineering, household water access, craft and material culture	"Priest-King", "assembly hall", "college" and some building functions are modern interpretations

The Great Bath's finely fitted baked bricks, gypsum mortar, bitumen waterproofing, stairways and controlled outlet securely establish specialised collective construction. Ritual use is plausible, but neither a named deity nor a priestly corporation follows from the structure alone.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Cemetery R-37 and working platforms at Harappa answer mortuary and production questions; the Great Bath and wells at Mohenjo-daro answer water and collective-building questions.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappa and Mohenjo-daro should not be memorised as interchangeable capitals. Harappa's Cemetery R-37, craft contexts and working platforms illuminate production and burial, whereas Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath, wells and drains foreground water-centred urbanism. Their shared seals, weights and construction traditions indicate integration. The buildings called granaries and the bust called Priest-King remain modern interpretations rather than deciphered Harappan descriptions.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro; Cemetery R-37 and the type-site association belong to Harappa.
- **Correct control:** Pair Harappa's production-mortuary evidence with Mohenjo-daro's water-built landscape.

MAINS USE

Use the pair to combine common standards, functional diversity and source caution.

MINI RECAP

Harappa = production/burial; Mohenjo-daro = water/public architecture.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SITE PRECISION I: HARAPPA AND MOHENJO-DARO

- > KEYWORDS: Ravi | Cemetery R-37 | working platforms | Great Bath | wells | Dancing Girl
- > ANSWER LINE: Pair Harappa's production-mortuary evidence with Mohenjo-daro's water-built landscape.
- > RECAP: Harappa = production/burial; Mohenjo-daro = water/public architecture.

SESSION 8 - SITE PRECISION II: DHOLAVIRA AND RAKHIGARHI

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Dholavira and Rakhigarhi widen the urban model beyond the classic Indus-core pair.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Dholavira demonstrates adaptive water urbanism; Rakhigarhi demonstrates the scale and scientific potential of the eastern domain.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Khadir
- Manhar-Mansar
- reservoirs
- signboard
- Haryana
- bioarchaeology

VISUAL FIRST

DHOLAVIRA: seasonal streams -> dams/channels -> reservoirs -> multi-sector stone city
RAKHIGARHI: inland mounds -> drains/crafts -> cemeteries -> bounded bioarchaeology

CORE TEACHING

Site	Secure evidence	What it supports	Required caution
Dholavira	Khadir island in Kutch; stone construction; multiple enclosed sectors; dams, channels, cisterns and reservoirs; large signboard	Regional planning, water harvesting and public display of writing	The plan is not a universal Harappan template; "stadium" and precise building functions remain interpretive
Rakhigarhi	Haryana; large multi-mound inland settlement; Early and Mature occupation; drains, craft areas and cemetery evidence	Urban scale beyond the Indus core, craft and bioarchaeology	Size rankings change with survey; one sampled genome cannot represent all Harappans

Dholavira lay between the seasonal Manhar and Mansar streams and converted a difficult water regime into a civic design problem. Rakhigarhi expands the urban map eastward and demonstrates why the civilisation cannot be reduced to two cities on the Indus.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Dholavira's reservoirs and signboard provide built and communicative evidence; Rakhigarhi's settlement, workshops, cemetery and sampled human remains connect city archaeology to laboratory study.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Dholavira makes ecological adaptation central to Harappan urbanism. Its stone-built sectors and reservoir network converted seasonal flows into stored water, unlike a simple copy of Mohenjo-daro. Rakhigarhi, a large Haryana complex with craft and cemetery evidence, demonstrates an inland urban focus. The sites enlarge the civilisation's geography, yet neither one genome nor changing size estimates should be converted into civilisation-wide certainty.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Dholavira has the signboard and reservoirs; one Rakhigarhi individual cannot define every Harappan population.
- **Correct control:** Dholavira demonstrates adaptive water urbanism; Rakhigarhi demonstrates the scale and scientific potential of the eastern domain.

MAINS USE

Use Dholavira for adaptation and Rakhigarhi for scale plus scientific-inference limits.

MINI RECAP

Both sites correct an Indus-core-only narrative.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SITE PRECISION II: DHOLAVIRA AND RAKHIGARHI

- > KEYWORDS: Khadir | Manhar-Mansar | reservoirs | signboard | Haryana | bioarchaeology
- > ANSWER LINE: Dholavira demonstrates adaptive water urbanism; Rakhigarhi demonstrates the scale and scientific potential of the eastern domain.
- > RECAP: Both sites correct an Indus-core-only narrative.

SESSION 9 - SITE PRECISION III: KALIBANGAN, LOTHAL AND BANAWALI

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

These regional centres connect farming, craft, water, planning and interpretation debates.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A site-feature answer earns marks when it adds the function caution to the correct location.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- ploughed field
- fire installations
- brick basin
- dockyard caution
- plough model
- moat

VISUAL FIRST

KALIBANGAN -> ploughed field + fire installations
LOTHAL -> bead/copper craft + brick basin ('dockyard' qualified)
BANAWALI -> fortified curved plan + moat + plough model

CORE TEACHING

Site	Secure evidence	What it supports	Required caution
Kalibangan	Ghaggar setting in Rajasthan; Early ploughed-field marks; fortified sectors; fire installations; site-specific wastewater arrangements	Farming practice, planning and possible ritual activity	Fire installations are not automatically Vedic altars; drainage differed from Mohenjo-daro
Lothal	Gujarat; large brick basin; bead and copper craft; drains; scale/measurement evidence; burials	Craft, exchange, measurement and maritime orientation	"Dockyard" is a leading archaeological interpretation, not an inscriptionally confirmed harbour
Banawali	Haryana; Early-Mature-Late sequence; fortified/curved plan; moat; plough model; seals, weights and craft/merchant evidence	Regional planning, farming and distributed economic activity	Seals and valuables outside a raised sector weaken a simple elite-space equation

These sites show coordinated civilisation without architectural sameness: a ploughed surface, a water basin and a distinctive fortified plan answer different questions and must not be swapped in site-feature MCQs.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

The early ploughed surface at Kalibangan, Lothal's basin and workshops, and Banawali's sequence and plough model support distinct regional arguments.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali show why site knowledge must remain relational. Kalibangan links planning to a preserved ploughed surface, Lothal links craft and exchange to a large basin, and Banawali links farming models to a distinctive fortified plan. Together they demonstrate regional pathways within Harappan integration. Fire installations are not automatically Vedic, and the term dockyard remains a functional interpretation rather than a translated label.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Do not swap Dholavira's signboard, Kalibangan's ploughed field and Lothal's basin.
- **Correct control:** A site-feature answer earns marks when it adds the function caution to the correct location.

MAINS USE

Use the trio to demonstrate regional variation within a shared civilisational system.

MINI RECAP

Correct pair first; inference limit second.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SITE PRECISION III: KALIBANGAN, LOTHAL AND BANAWALI

-> KEYWORDS: ploughed field | fire installations | brick basin | dockyard caution | plough model | moat

-> ANSWER LINE: A site-feature answer earns marks when it adds the function caution to the correct location.

-> RECAP: Correct pair first; inference limit second.

SESSION 10 - SITE PRECISION IV: CHANHUDARO, SURKOTADA AND SHORTUGAI

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Specialist, fortified and outpost sites reveal different functions within the wider network.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Settlement function cannot be read from size or monumentality alone.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Chanhudaro
- craft town
- Surkotada
- equid caution
- Shortugai
- procurement route

VISUAL FIRST

CHANHUDARO: craft concentration without classic citadel

SURKOTADA: fortified Kutch site + disputed equid identification

SHORTUGAI: Afghanistan route node near mineral corridors

CORE TEACHING

Site	Secure evidence	What it supports	Required caution
Chanhudaro	Sindh; unfortified specialist settlement; bead-making, shell, seals, weights and other workshop debris	Concentrated craft production without a conventional citadel	A specialist town is not merely a village and does not prove a state factory
Surkotada	Kutch; small fortified settlement; reported equid remains	Regional fortification and the need for faunal-method caution	Identification, context and significance of horse/equid remains are disputed
Shortugai	North-east Afghanistan near highland mineral routes	Long-distance procurement and route connectivity	An outpost does not by itself prove direct territorial annexation by one empire

Chanhudaro separates urban function from monumentality, Surkotada separates a reported bone from a civilisation-wide animal profile, and Shortugai separates commercial reach from political sovereignty.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Workshop debris at Chanhudaro, fortification and disputed bones at Surkotada, and Shortugai's route position each answer a different economic or methodological question.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

The three sites prevent a monument-centred picture of Harappan power. Chanhudaro's workshops show specialised production without a conventional citadel, Surkotada shows regional fortification but only disputed horse/equid evidence, and Shortugai marks procurement reach toward highland resources. These facts support functional differentiation and connectivity. They do not prove state factories, a horse-centred society or direct imperial annexation of Afghanistan.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** A rare disputed bone is not a civilisation-defining animal, and a trade outpost is not automatically a province.
- **Correct control:** Settlement function cannot be read from size or monumentality alone.

MAINS USE

Use one site for craft, one for evidence caution and one for long-distance procurement.

MINI RECAP

Function, context and scale control the inference.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SITE PRECISION IV: CHANHUDARO, SURKOTADA AND SHORTUGAI

- > KEYWORDS: Chanhudaro | craft town | Surkotada | equid caution | Shortugai | procurement route
- > ANSWER LINE: Settlement function cannot be read from size or monumentality alone.
- > RECAP: Function, context and scale control the inference.

SESSION 11 - SUBSISTENCE, CROPS, PASTORALISM AND ECOLOGICAL FLEXIBILITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan subsistence combined cultivation, herding, fishing and wild resources in regionally varied proportions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The food base was diversified and ecological, not a uniform wheat-barley monoculture.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- wheat
- barley
- millets
- regional rice
- cotton
- cattle

VISUAL FIRST

WINTER CROPS: wheat/barley ----+
SUMMER/REGIONAL: millets/rice --+> mixed food and fibre system
HERDS: cattle/sheep/goat -----+
FISH/WILD RESOURCES -----+>

CORE TEACHING

Category	Evidence	Caution
Cereals	Wheat and barley widespread; millets and rice more important in some regions	Crop packages varied by ecology and phase
Pulses/oilseeds	Peas, lentils, sesame and mustard among reported crops	Presence does not measure dependence or yield
Cotton	Early cotton cultivation/textile evidence	"First" claims should be tied to archaeological context
Cattle	Humped cattle prominent; sheep/goat, buffalo, pig and other animals	Herd composition and use varied
Fishing/wild resources	Fish, shellfish, wild animals and gathered resources	Urbanism did not eliminate wild-resource use
Agriculture	Floodplain, rain-fed and locally managed water strategies	No one irrigation system covered the civilisation

Harappan food production was flexible and regionally diverse. Gujarat, the Indus plains, Ghaggar-Hakra settlements and highland/coastal zones did not use identical crop or water systems.

Horse caution

Horse/equid remains reported at sites such as Surkotada are rare and disputed in identification/context. The horse was not a characteristic or securely central Harappan economic animal.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Crop remains, animal bones, fishing evidence and cotton-related finds vary across Indus, Ghaggar-Hakra and Gujarat settings.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan food production supported cities through diversity rather than one fixed package. Wheat and barley were important, while millets and rice had stronger regional roles; cattle, sheep, goats and aquatic resources widened the risk portfolio. Cotton also connected agriculture to textile production. The assemblages show adaptation to local ecologies, but crop presence alone cannot measure yield, ownership or uniform dependence across the civilisation.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Rice at some sites does not make rice the universal staple; disputed horse remains do not create a horse economy.
- **Correct control:** The food base was diversified and ecological, not a uniform wheat-barley monoculture.

MAINS USE

Connect ecological diversity to urban resilience, rural labour and regional transformation.

MINI RECAP

Food systems varied by season, region and settlement role.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SUBSISTENCE, CROPS, PASTORALISM AND ECOLOGICAL FLEXIBILITY

- > KEYWORDS: wheat | barley | millets | regional rice | cotton | cattle
- > ANSWER LINE: The food base was diversified and ecological, not a uniform wheat-barley monoculture.
- > RECAP: Food systems varied by season, region and settlement role.

SESSION 12 - CRAFT SPECIALISATION, METALLURGY, CERAMICS AND ART

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan material culture records skilled production in stone, shell, faience, textiles, ceramics and copper-bronze metallurgy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Craft evidence reveals technical chains and exchange more securely than it reveals guilds, caste or artist biographies.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- beads
- faience
- shell
- lost-wax casting
- red ware
- bronze

VISUAL FIRST

RAW MATERIAL -> preparation -> specialist technique -> finished object -> exchange/use

carnelian	heating/drilling	beads
copper/tin	alloy/casting	bronze objects
clay	forming/firing	red ware/terracottas

CORE TEACHING

Craft	Evidence/centres	Historical significance
Bead-making	Chanhudaro, Lothal and other workshops	Skill, standardisation and exchange
Shell	Nageshwar, coastal/Gujarat sites	Coastal-resource procurement and specialised craft
Faience	Beads, bangles and small objects	Controlled high-temperature production
Seal-cutting	Steatite seals and sealings	Administration, identity, exchange and symbolism
Metallurgy	Copper/bronze tools, vessels, mirrors and figurines; gold/silver/lead objects	Alloying, casting and specialist production
Textiles	Spindle whorls, impressions and cotton evidence	Household and specialist spinning/weaving
Pottery	Wheel-made red ware, often with black designs	Domestic use, chronology and regional variation

No iron defines the Mature Harappan technological system. Stone, bone, shell, wood and copper/bronze coexisted.

ANALYSIS: Craft concentration can indicate workshops and occupational specialisation; it does not automatically identify guilds, state factories or hereditary castes.

Object/form	Secure fact	Interpretive caution
"Dancing Girl"	Bronze figurine from Mohenjo-daro	Pose/name are modern description; it is not a portrait biography
"Priest-King"	Stone male bust from Mohenjo-daro	Priest, king and identity are unknown
Female figurines	Varied terracotta figures	Not one automatic "Mother Goddess" cult
Seals	Animals, composite beings, signs and ritual/administrative imagery	Meaning remains undeciphered
Pottery	Red ware, black painting and regional forms	Decoration is not ethnicity
Toys/models	Carts, animals and human figures	Can combine play, teaching, ritual and representation

Boundary: Indian Art and Culture owns detailed formal analysis. Topic 06 owns material context, historical use and PYQ identification.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Chanhudaro and Lothal workshops, Nageshwar shell work, faience objects, wheel-made pottery and the bronze Dancing Girl reveal different technical chains.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan craft specialisation joined knowledge, labour and exchange. Long carnelian beads required controlled preparation and drilling, shell work depended on coastal procurement, and the bronze Dancing Girl demonstrates casting skill. Standard forms could circulate widely while pottery and motifs retained regional variation. Workshop concentration supports occupational specialisation, but it does not by itself prove hereditary guilds, caste or state ownership of production.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Mature Harappan metallurgy is copper-bronze based; iron and coinage are anachronistic distractors.

- **Correct control:** Craft evidence reveals technical chains and exchange more securely than it reveals guilds, caste or artist biographies.

MAINS USE

Use chaîne opératoire logic: raw material -> technique -> labour -> distribution -> inference limit.

MINI RECAP

Technique is observable; social institution requires more evidence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

CRAFT SPECIALISATION, METALLURGY, CERAMICS AND ART

-> KEYWORDS: beads | faience | shell | lost-wax casting | red ware | bronze

-> ANSWER LINE: Craft evidence reveals technical chains and exchange more securely than it reveals guilds, caste or artist biographies.

-> RECAP: Technique is observable; social institution requires more evidence.

SESSION 13 - WEIGHTS, MEASURES AND STANDARDISATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan metrology used graded weights and measuring devices within production and exchange.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Standard measures prove shared technical conventions, not minted money or a known empire.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- cubical weights
- graded series
- scale
- measurement
- brick norm
- coordination

VISUAL FIRST

CRAFT INPUT -> measured quantity -> standard weight/scale -> exchange comparison

```

|
shared technical convention

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coordination certain; political form uncertain

CORE TEACHING

- carefully graded stone weights supported exchange and production;
- shell/ivory scales and measurement markings show linear measurement;
- mature brick ratios and repeated seal forms show shared technical norms;
- standardisation across regions supports communication and coordination;
- local variation and changing series remain important.

ANALYSIS: Do not reduce the entire weight system to one memorised "multiple of 16" rule. Analyse sequence, material, context and regional variation.

ANALYSIS: Standard weights do not prove coinage; no Harappan metal coinage is securely known.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Carefully graded stone weights, shell or ivory scales, repeated seal forms and brick proportions provide converging standardisation evidence.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Metrology made dispersed production and exchange comparable. Cubical stone weights and graduated scales created repeatable quantities, while brick proportions carried modular practice into construction. The convergence suggests communication, training and enforcement of norms across regions. It does not establish metal coinage, a single immutable numerical rule or one central treasury controlling every transaction.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Weights are not coins, and a memorised 'multiple of sixteen' slogan should not replace contextual analysis.
- **Correct control:** Standard measures prove shared technical conventions, not minted money or a known empire.

MAINS USE

Move from measurement to coordination, then stop before asserting a specific constitution.

MINI RECAP

Shared quantities reveal integration; authority remains debated.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

WEIGHTS, MEASURES AND STANDARDISATION

- > KEYWORDS: cubical weights | graded series | scale | measurement | brick norm | coordination
- > ANSWER LINE: Standard measures prove shared technical conventions, not minted money or a known empire.
- > RECAP: Shared quantities reveal integration; authority remains debated.

SESSION 14 - INTERNAL EXCHANGE, TRANSPORT AND URBAN-RURAL ECONOMY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Internal exchange moved food, animals, raw materials and finished goods among ecological and settlement zones.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Harappan prosperity rested on linked production and circulation, not long-distance trade alone.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- raw-material procurement
- bullock cart
- river craft
- coastal route
- surplus
- redistribution

VISUAL FIRST

FARM/PASTURE -> food/fibre -> CITY
MINE/QUARRY -> metal/stone -> WORKSHOP -> finished goods
COAST -> shell/fish/salt -> TOWN
ROUTES: cart + pack animal + river/coastal craft

CORE TEACHING

Internal system

Cities lacked all necessary raw materials. Networks moved:

- copper, tin and other metals;
- lapis, carnelian and other stones;
- shell, timber and food;
- finished beads, pottery, seals and metal products.

Bullock carts, pack animals, river craft and coastal boats likely served different routes. Exchange could use commodities and standard weights without coinage.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Copper, stone, shell, timber and food had to move because no city possessed every required resource; carts, boats and route nodes connected zones.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Internal circulation was the foundation beneath Harappan urbanism. Cities required food and fibre from rural producers, metals and stones from resource zones, and shell from coasts; workshops returned finished goods through the network. Standard weights and seals could facilitate transactions across this diversity. The evidence demonstrates connectivity, but the proportions of market exchange, redistribution, gift and direct procurement remain uncertain.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Do not explain cities only through Mesopotamian trade while ignoring their subcontinental supply system.
- **Correct control:** Harappan prosperity rested on linked production and circulation, not long-distance trade alone.

MAINS USE

Build the economy from rural base to craft and transport before adding overseas exchange.

MINI RECAP

Local and regional circulation sustained the cities.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

INTERNAL EXCHANGE, TRANSPORT AND URBAN-RURAL ECONOMY

-> KEYWORDS: raw-material procurement | bullock cart | river craft | coastal route | surplus | redistribution

-> ANSWER LINE: Harappan prosperity rested on linked production and circulation, not long-distance trade alone.

-> RECAP: Local and regional circulation sustained the cities.

SESSION 15 - EXTERNAL TRADE, MESOPOTAMIAN EVIDENCE AND MELUHHA CAUTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

External exchange linked the Harappan world with Gulf and Mesopotamian circuits through objects, materials and textual references.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Meluhha is strong evidence for an Indus-related eastern trading sphere, but its exact boundary and political meaning remain debated.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Meluhha
- Dilmun
- Magan
- Gulf
- Oman
- contact not colony

VISUAL FIRST

HARAPPAN COAST/ROUTES -> MAGAN/OMAN ZONE -> DILMUN/GULF -> MESOPOTAMIA

objects + raw materials + textual names

CONTACT CERTAIN -> route/volume/control only partly known

CORE TEACHING

Mesopotamian and maritime links

Term/evidence	Safe interpretation
Meluhha/Meluha	Mesopotamian term probably referring to the Indus/Harappan region or a wider eastern trading zone; exact reach debated
Dilmun	Gulf intermediary commonly associated with Bahrain
Magan/Makan	Oman/Makran-linked zone in Gulf trade discussions
Mesopotamian texts/objects	Harappan merchants, materials or products entered western exchange systems
Oman/Gulf and coastal finds	Maritime links and raw-material procurement

ANALYSIS: Imported objects prove contact, not a Harappan colony, trade volume or direct state control.

ANALYSIS: Lothal's basin may support maritime orientation, but the "dockyard" label should remain qualified.

NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Mesopotamian references to Meluhha, Dilmun and Magan, together with Gulf and Oman finds, place Harappan-related goods and people in wider exchange.

CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Mesopotamian texts and archaeological finds demonstrate contact beyond South Asia. Meluhha is conventionally linked to the Indus or a wider eastern zone, while Dilmun and Magan belong to intermediary Gulf discussions. These references strengthen a maritime and overland exchange model. They do not translate the Indus script, define Meluhha as one city, quantify trade or prove that one Harappan king controlled the routes.

UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Meluhha is not a deciphered Harappan name for Dholavira, and Dilmun was not a Harappan capital.
- **Correct control:** Meluhha is strong evidence for an Indus-related eastern trading sphere, but its exact boundary and political meaning remain debated.

MAINS USE

Use external evidence after internal economy and qualify identity, route and volume.

MINI RECAP

Contact is secure; boundaries and control are not.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

EXTERNAL TRADE, MESOPOTAMIAN EVIDENCE AND MELUHHA CAUTION

- ```
-> KEYWORDS: Meluhha | Dilmun | Magan | Gulf | Oman | contact not colony
-> ANSWER LINE: Meluhha is strong evidence for an Indus-related eastern trading sphere, but its
exact boundary and political meaning remain debated.
-> RECAP: Contact is secure; boundaries and control are not.
```

## SESSION 16 - SEALS, SCRIPT, LANGUAGE AND COMMUNICATION LIMITS

## DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

The Indus sign system is patterned and analysable but remains undeciphered.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Study medium, direction, context and sign pattern without claiming a language, king-list or translation.

## MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- undeciphered
- short inscriptions
- right-to-left
- seals
- sealings
- language unknown

## VISUAL FIRST

OBJECT/SEAL -> signs + image + find-context

pattern analysis      administrative/identity hypotheses

NO SECURE LANGUAGE, KING-LIST, LAW CODE OR DOCTRINE

## CORE TEACHING

## Secure characteristics

- the sign system remains undeciphered;
- inscriptions are generally short and often occur on seals, sealings, pottery, tablets and other objects;
- the corpus contains several hundred signs, with estimates depending on variant counting;
- many inscriptions appear to run right-to-left; some layouts may use other directions or multi-line alternation;
- language and exact sign values are unknown.

ANALYSIS: "Logo-syllabic" is a proposed description, not a decipherment.

ANALYSIS: A short seal inscription may concern identity, office, commodity, ownership or ritual, but function is not settled.

ANALYSIS: Similar signs do not prove a later script/language descended directly from Harappan writing.

### NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Short inscriptions occur on seals, sealings, pottery, tablets and other objects; many appear right-to-left, but sign values and language remain unknown.

**CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION**

The script permits controlled analysis without decipherment. Recurrent signs, direction and object contexts can be compared, and sealings may relate to identity, goods or administration. Yet short texts and the absence of a verified bilingual inscription prevent secure translation. Consequently, claims about language, royal names, legal codes or religious doctrine exceed the evidence even when a proposed decipherment seems visually persuasive.

### UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Similarity to a later sign system is not proof of direct descent or a successful decipherment.
- **Correct control:** Study medium, direction, context and sign pattern without claiming a language, king-list or translation.

### MAINS USE

Use the unread script to explain why material evidence is strong for practice but weak for named institutions.

### MINI RECAP

Pattern is evidence; translation is not achieved.

### CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SEALS, SCRIPT, LANGUAGE AND COMMUNICATION LIMITS

-> KEYWORDS: undeciphered | short inscriptions | right-to-left | seals | sealings | language unknown

-> ANSWER LINE: Study medium, direction, context and sign pattern without claiming a language, king-list or translation.

-> RECAP: Pattern is evidence; translation is not achieved.

## SESSION 17 - POLITY, STANDARDISATION, LABOUR AND AUTHORITY

### DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan political organisation is reconstructed from coordination, settlement and labour evidence rather than from named rulers.

### ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

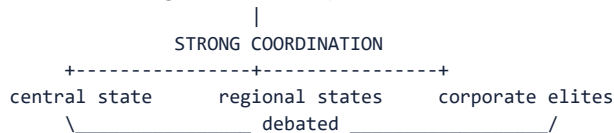
Strong integration is secure; empire, city-states and corporate elites remain competing models.

### MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **coordination**
- **centralised state**
- **city-states**
- **corporate elites**
- **labour mobilisation**
- **no king-list**

## VISUAL FIRST

OBSERVED: bricks + weights + seals + public works + settlement hierarchy



## CORE TEACHING

No securely identified royal tombs, king lists, palaces, monumental temples or named dynasties survive.

| Model                               | Evidence used                                                                 | Limitation                                         |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Centralised state/empire            | Wide standardisation, urban planning, seals and weights                       | No named sovereign or uniform administrative text  |
| Several regional states/city-states | Large regional centres and layout variation                                   | Shared norms and exchange crossed regions          |
| Corporate/decentralised elites      | Limited royal display, collective standards and mercantile/craft coordination | Mechanism of coercion and decision remains unknown |

ANALYSIS: The exact polity is unresolved. The safest claim is **strong coordination across urban and exchange systems, with debated political form**.

Large platforms, reservoirs, fortifications and drains required labour mobilisation. The record shows organised tasks and standards, but does not by itself disclose taxation, corvee, citizenship or the legal status of workers.

## NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Shared weights and seals, major public works and regionally large centres support authority, while the absence of deciphered king-lists, royal tombs and securely identified palaces limits its form.

## CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan authority must be inferred between two errors: denying organisation and inventing monarchy. Dholavira's reservoirs, Mohenjo-daro's drainage and wide metrological norms required sustained labour and coordination. These systems make a purely unorganised society implausible. However, without readable institutions, royal tombs or named dynasties, they cannot choose conclusively among a central state, regional states and corporate elite networks.

## UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Uniform bricks do not by themselves prove one emperor, and absent royal display does not prove absent government.
- **Correct control:** Strong integration is secure; empire, city-states and corporate elites remain competing models.

## MAINS USE

State the secure coordination claim before evaluating alternative polity models.

## MINI RECAP

Capacity is visible; constitutional form is not.

## CLOSING RECALL FLOW

POLITY, STANDARDISATION, LABOUR AND AUTHORITY

-> KEYWORDS: coordination | centralised state | city-states | corporate elites | labour mobilisation | no king-list

-> ANSWER LINE: Strong integration is secure; empire, city-states and corporate elites remain competing models.

-> RECAP: Capacity is visible; constitutional form is not.

# SESSION 18 - SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION, HOUSEHOLDS AND BURIAL EVIDENCE

## DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Social reconstruction uses patterned differences in houses, objects, craft and burials while avoiding direct labels such as caste or matriarchy.

## ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Material inequality can be argued; a complete social hierarchy cannot be read from one house, grave or figurine.

## MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- house-size variation
- grave goods
- occupational diversity
- health
- status
- taphonomy

## VISUAL FIRST

HOUSE SIZE/FACILITIES + RARE MATERIALS + CRAFT ZONES + BURIAL VARIATION  
|  
differentiated access / occupation / treatment  
|  
NOT automatic caste, slavery, matriarchy or fixed class map

## CORE TEACHING

### Evidence

- unequal house sizes and facilities;
- luxury/rare materials and ornaments;
- specialised craft areas;
- settlement hierarchy;
- variation in burials and grave goods;
- wide technical standardisation.

### Responsible inference

These support occupational diversity and social differentiation. They do not securely establish:

- caste;
- slavery as an institution;
- matriarchy;
- exact property rights;
- one class system;
- a "peaceful civilisation".

ANALYSIS: Fortifications, weapons, trauma and uneven destruction are insufficient to make either universal peace or endemic warfare a settled description.

Burials preserve selected practices, not a census of the living. Grave goods, body treatment, pathology and isotope results require sample size, preservation, age/sex estimation and cemetery context.

## NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Unequal domestic facilities, luxury materials, specialised production and varied grave treatment support differentiated access and occupation.

### CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan society was differentiated, but its categories are not directly named. Variation in houses and facilities, concentrations of rare objects and specialised workshops indicate unequal access and occupational diversity; cemeteries add mortuary differences and biological data. These strands can converge on social inequality. No single grave or house, however, proves caste, slavery, patriarchy, hereditary rank or the lived status of every household.

### UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Burial wealth is selected mortuary treatment, not a transparent balance sheet of lifetime status.
- **Correct control:** Material inequality can be argued; a complete social hierarchy cannot be read from one house, grave or figurine.

### MAINS USE

Use two independent evidence streams and explicitly state the social label they cannot prove.

### MINI RECAP

Difference is visible; institutional identity remains uncertain.

### CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION, HOUSEHOLDS AND BURIAL EVIDENCE

-> KEYWORDS: house-size variation | grave goods | occupational diversity | health | status | taphonomy

-> ANSWER LINE: Material inequality can be argued; a complete social hierarchy cannot be read from one house, grave or figurine.

-> RECAP: Difference is visible; institutional identity remains uncertain.

## SESSION 19 - RELIGION, ICONOGRAPHY AND CONTINUITY CLAIMS

### DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan religion is reconstructed from material practices and images whose names and doctrines are unknown.

### ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Describe the object first, offer alternatives second, and project later traditions only with explicit caution.

### MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **horned figure**
- **female figurines**
- **pipal**
- **fire installations**
- **Great Bath**
- **back-projection**

## VISUAL FIRST

OBSERVATION -> horned figure / figurine / tree motif / fire feature / bath

POSSIBLE USE -> ritual, domestic, industrial, symbolic, playful

LIMIT -> no secure named deity, creed or unchanged later continuity

## CORE TEACHING

| Evidence                   | Possible interpretation                             | Caution                                           |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Female figurines           | Household ritual, fertility, toys or representation | "Mother Goddess" is not established               |
| Horned seated figure seal  | Deity, ritual figure or symbolic composition        | "Pashupati/proto-Shiva" is contested              |
| Pipal and animal motifs    | Sacred symbolism or identity marks                  | Meaning is not textually known                    |
| Fire installations         | Domestic, industrial or ritual use                  | "Fire altar" does not make them Vedic             |
| Great Bath                 | Collective/ritual bathing possibility               | Secure function is waterproof public architecture |
| Burials/grave goods        | Mortuary customs and social memory                  | No single afterlife doctrine can be recovered     |
| Possible linga-like stones | Cultic or functional objects                        | Later Hindu identification is uncertain           |

No monumental temple or unified state religion has been securely identified.

## NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

The so-called Pashupati seal, varied female figurines, pipal/animal motifs, fire installations, burials and the Great Bath create a ritual evidence set without a deciphered theology.

## CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Harappan ritual interpretation is strongest when it begins with form and context. A horned seated figure, varied terracotta females, pipal motifs and fire installations show repeated symbolic or ritual possibilities. Comparison with later traditions may generate hypotheses about Shiva, goddess worship or sacred bathing. Because no text confirms these names and functions vary by context, continuity must be argued as selective possibility rather than direct unbroken identity.

## UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** The labels Pashupati and Mother Goddess are hypotheses, not translations from Harappan texts.
- **Correct control:** Describe the object first, offer alternatives second, and project later traditions only with explicit caution.

## MAINS USE

Build an evidence ladder from object to possible practice to continuity limit.

## MINI RECAP

Material ritual is plausible; named theology is not recovered.

## CLOSING RECALL FLOW

RELIGION, ICONOGRAPHY AND CONTINUITY CLAIMS

-> KEYWORDS: horned figure | female figurines | pipal | fire installations | Great Bath | back-projection

-> ANSWER LINE: Describe the object first, offer alternatives second, and project later traditions only with explicit caution.

-> RECAP: Material ritual is plausible; named theology is not recovered.

## SESSION 20 - ENVIRONMENT, RIVERS, PALAEOCLIMATE AND MULTI-CAUSAL DEURBANISATION

### DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Harappan decline was an uneven weakening of urban integration caused by interacting environmental, economic and social changes.

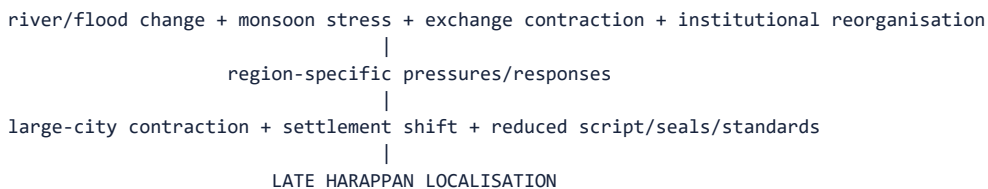
### ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Explain mechanisms region by region and call the outcome deurbanisation, localisation and transformation.

### MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- post-1900 BCE
- river change
- aridity
- trade contraction
- deurbanisation
- regional causation

### VISUAL FIRST



### CORE TEACHING

After c. 1900 BCE, major urban traits declined unevenly:

- large cities contracted or were abandoned;
- script, seals, long-distance standards and some crafts diminished;
- settlement distributions shifted;
- regional pottery traditions became more prominent;
- agriculture diversified;
- smaller/rural communities continued.

### Cause families

| Cause family                    | Possible contribution                        | Why it cannot stand alone                                           |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| River change/flood              | Damaged or redirected particular settlements | Different sites had different hydrologies                           |
| Aridity/monsoon stress          | Raised water and agricultural risk           | Chronology/proxy scale and social response vary                     |
| Trade contraction               | Reduced demand/raw-material circulation      | Internal production and rural life continued                        |
| Social/political reorganisation | Weakened integrative institutions            | Direct institutional evidence is scarce                             |
| Disease/resource pressure       | Possible local stress                        | Evidence remains incomplete                                         |
| Invasion/incursion              | Contact or violence may occur locally        | No evidence supports one Aryan invasion destroying the civilisation |

ANALYSIS: Prefer **deurbanisation, localisation and transformation** to "sudden extinction".

ANALYSIS: Climate, invasion, flood or river shift should not be presented as one universal cause.

### Continuities may include

- crops, livestock and rural settlement;
- some pottery and craft traditions;
- regional population continuity and interaction;
- selected symbols or practices.

### Discontinuities include

- urban scale and integrated settlement networks;
- script use;
- seal system and standardisation;
- aspects of long-distance exchange and specialised production.

ANALYSIS: A similar motif, crop or ritual does not prove an unchanged Harappan-to-later tradition.

ANALYSIS: Detailed Harappan-Vedic identity, language and genetics belong to topic 07. Topic 06's safe conclusion is continuity plus major institutional discontinuity.

### NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

Post-1900 BCE contraction of major cities, reduced script/seal use, changing settlement geography and regionalised material traditions demonstrate transformation rather than disappearance.

### CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

No single cause fits every Harappan region. River shifts or floods affected particular settlements, climatic stress altered agricultural risk, exchange contraction reduced some urban demand, and political-economic reorganisation may have weakened integrative institutions. The archaeological result was uneven contraction, migration and localisation after about 1900 BCE. Continued rural settlements and regional traditions rule out both instant extinction and a universally proven invasion.

### UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** Do not use one palaeoclimate proxy to explain every site or to settle the Ghaggar-Hakra/Sarasvati identity.
- **Correct control:** Explain mechanisms region by region and call the outcome deurbanisation, localisation and transformation.

### MAINS USE

Write cause -> mechanism -> regional evidence -> response -> continuity, not a list of theories.

### MINI RECAP

Multiple pressures, varied responses, continued communities.

### CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ENVIRONMENT, RIVERS, PALAEOCLIMATE AND MULTI-CAUSAL DEURBANISATION

-> KEYWORDS: post-1900 BCE | river change | aridity | trade contraction | deurbanisation | regional causation

-> ANSWER LINE: Explain mechanisms region by region and call the outcome deurbanisation, localisation and transformation.

-> RECAP: Multiple pressures, varied responses, continued communities.

## SESSION 21 - SCIENTIFIC ARCHAEOLOGY, GENETICS, COMPARISON AND LEGACY

### DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Scientific methods refine bounded questions about date, diet, mobility, materials, health and ancestry; they do not replace archaeological context.

## ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A sample answers only the question its context, preservation and scale can support.

### MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- radiocarbon
- archaeobotany
- isotopes
- provenance
- ancient DNA
- sample limits

### VISUAL FIRST

QUESTION -> secure context -> method -> result -> representativeness check -> bounded inference  
|  
chronology / diet / mobility / material source / ancestry  
|  
never automatic language, religion, empire or total population history

### CORE TEACHING

- The published 2019 Rakhigarhi ancient-DNA study provides evidence from one sampled individual.
- It is relevant to population history but cannot represent every Harappan region, identify language, caste, religion or polity, or settle the full Aryan question.
- Isotope, skeletal, palaeopathological and environmental studies can widen diet, mobility and health reconstruction when results are published and context is secure.

ANALYSIS: Announced analyses, transferred remains or proposed facial reconstruction are not completed findings.##### Bounded comparison with Egypt and Mesopotamia

| Axis            | Harappan pattern                                                                                 | Bounded comparative use                                                                                           |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Text            | Undeciphered, mostly short inscriptions                                                          | Egypt/Mesopotamia provide readable royal and administrative texts; absence of equivalent access limits comparison |
| Monumentality   | Strong civic, water and settlement works; no securely identified royal tomb or monumental temple | Do not infer weak authority merely because pyramids or ziggurats are absent                                       |
| Standardisation | Bricks, weights, seals and urban conventions across a wide area                                  | Comparable coordination need not arise through identical institutions                                             |
| Trade           | Mesopotamian references and Gulf finds show contact                                              | Contact did not erase separate cultural systems                                                                   |

### Legacy

Harappan legacies are best framed as questions of transmitted practices, regional population continuity and later reuse rather than as a single unbroken civilisational essence. Crops, craft skills, settlement knowledge and selected symbols may continue, while urban scale, script and integrated institutions clearly changed.

### NAMED EVIDENCE / EXAMPLE

The 2019 Rakhigarhi ancient-DNA publication concerns one sampled individual; isotopes, palaeopathology, provenance and environmental proxies likewise depend on context and representativeness.

### CLAIM -> EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Scientific archaeology strengthens Harappan history when the claim matches the sample. Radiocarbon can refine chronology, isotopes can test mobility or diet, provenance can trace materials, and ancient DNA can illuminate ancestry. The Rakhigarhi result was important precisely as a context-specific individual, not as a census of language, religion or every Harappan population. Comparison with Egypt and Mesopotamia likewise clarifies missing textual access without ranking civilisations by monuments.

### UPSC TRAP

- **Wrong shortcut:** One genome, isotope value or climate record cannot identify a language, prove a migration narrative or explain the whole civilisation.
- **Correct control:** A sample answers only the question its context, preservation and scale can support.

### MAINS USE

Use method -> sample -> result -> scale limit, then give a qualified legacy verdict.

### MINI RECAP

Science narrows uncertainty; it does not abolish it.

### CLOSING RECALL FLOW

SCIENTIFIC ARCHAEOLOGY, GENETICS, COMPARISON AND LEGACY

- > KEYWORDS: radiocarbon | archaeobotany | isotopes | provenance | ancient DNA | sample limits
- > ANSWER LINE: A sample answers only the question its context, preservation and scale can support.
- > RECAP: Science narrows uncertainty; it does not abolish it.

### COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

```
[1] NAME + TIME + METHOD
```

1  
v

I  
v

## iv

1  
v1  
v

1  
v

## 1

## 1

## 1

## 1

river/flood change + monsoon stress + exchange contraction + reorganisation  
-> uneven post-1900 BCE city contraction, settlement shifts, reduced script/seals  
-> Late Harappan regionalisation, agricultural diversification and continuity  
NOT one invasion, one drought, one river or instant extinction.

|  
v

[12] PYQ + ANSWER SPINE

2019 non-Harappan site -> Sohgauna [inferred; key unavailable]  
2021 reservoir town -> Dholavira [inferred; key unavailable]  
2025 Dancing Girl -> bronze [official local Set-A key]  
2026 household inference -> statements 1 and 2 [inferred; provisional key]  
2025 Mains architecture -> plan + material + water + sites + variation + caution

FINAL FORMULA:

definition -> phase/map -> named evidence -> mechanism -> alternative/limit  
-> regional qualification -> verdict: coordinated diversity and transformation.

## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

### 32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. The 128 option explanations and 32 traps are individually worded and question-specific.

#### Q1

With reference to Harappan chronology, consider the following statements:

1. The Mature Harappan phase is conventionally placed c. 2600-1900 BCE.
2. The Early Harappan phase represents regional and proto-urban development.
3. The Late Harappan phase is best treated as an interval without settlement continuity.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 2 and 3 only

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: Statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.

**Examiner trap 1:** Treat phase labels as archaeological processes, not ethnic replacements.

#### Q2

Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched?

- A. Kalibangan - Dancing Girl figurine
- B. Dholavira - reservoirs and a distinctive tripartite plan

- C. Lothal - giant signboard
- D. Harappa - Great Bath

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Kalibangan - Dancing Girl figurine" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **B:** Correct: Dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Lothal - giant signboard" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappa - Great Bath" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.

**Examiner trap 2:** Do not move Dholavira's reservoirs or signboard to another site.

**Q3**

Consider the following site-feature pairs:

1. Mohenjo-daro - Great Bath
2. Kalibangan - ploughed-field evidence
3. Chanhudaro - specialised craft production

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- A. Only two
- B. Only one
- C. All three
- D. None

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Only two" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Only one" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **C:** Correct: All three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "None" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.

**Examiner trap 3:** A three-pair question is lost by one swapped site-feature association.

**Q4**

Which one of the following is the most appropriate inference from shared brick conventions, weights and seals across many Mature Harappan settlements?

- A. They prove a deciphered imperial law code.

- B. They prove the presence of coinage.
- C. They prove every settlement had the same layout.
- D. They indicate wide shared norms and coordination, while the exact political mechanism remains debated.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove a deciphered imperial law code." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove the presence of coinage." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove every settlement had the same layout." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **D:** Correct: Material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.

**Examiner trap 4:** Standardisation supports coordination but does not decipher an imperial constitution.

**Q5**

The Great Bath is especially useful in a Harappan architecture answer because it provides evidence for

- A. water-related public or collective built form at Mohenjo-daro
- B. a translated ritual doctrine
- C. a securely identified royal palace at Harappa
- D. a universal three-part town plan

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: Its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a translated ritual doctrine" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "a securely identified royal palace at Harappa" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a universal three-part town plan" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.

**Examiner trap 5:** Great Bath proves waterproof collective architecture, not a named creed.

**Q6**

Why is Dholavira particularly important for correcting a simplistic account of Harappan town planning?

- A. It contains the Great Bath.
- B. Its tripartite plan and reservoirs show regional variation within broader urban coordination.
- C. It proves that all Harappan settlements were coastal ports.
- D. It alone has evidence of any water management.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It contains the Great Bath." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.
- **B:** Correct: Dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It proves that all Harappan settlements were coastal ports." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "It alone has evidence of any water management." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.

**Examiner trap 6:** Dholavira corrects the universal two-part-city stereotype.

#### Q7

Consider the following statements about Harappan drainage:

1. Household drains, wells and street drains are material evidence for planned built practice.
2. Their presence directly identifies the title of the authority that maintained them.
3. Their layout can support an inference of recurring civic maintenance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

**Answer: C.**

#### Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **C:** Correct: Statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.

**Examiner trap 7:** Drainage reveals maintenance needs, not the title of the maintaining authority.

#### Q8

With reference to functional labels in Harappan archaeology, which one of the following is correct?

- A. 'Granary' establishes that a building stored state tax in grain.
- B. The basin at Lothal has been conclusively translated as a harbour.
- C. 'Citadel' is a Harappan word preserved in inscriptions.

- D. Terms such as 'dockyard' and 'granary' are conventional interpretations that must be tested against context.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "'Granary' establishes that a building stored state tax in grain." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "The basin at Lothal has been conclusively translated as a harbour." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "'Citadel' is a Harappan word preserved in inscriptions." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **D:** Correct: These are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.

**Examiner trap 8:** Granary, dockyard and citadel are analytical labels, not readable Harappan nouns.

**Q9**

Which one of the following combinations best represents a Harappan economic foundation?

- A. agriculture and pastoral resources linked to specialised craft and exchange
- B. only long-distance trade, with no local production
- C. temple estates linked to deciphered tax records
- D. iron smelting linked to punch-marked coinage

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: Urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "only long-distance trade, with no local production" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "temple estates linked to deciphered tax records" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "iron smelting linked to punch-marked coinage" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.

**Examiner trap 9:** Long-distance trade supplemented; it did not replace agriculture and pastoral supply.

**Q10**

Which one of the following is correctly associated with Harappan textile production?

- A. punch-marked coins and guild seals
- B. spindle whorls, textile impressions and cotton production
- C. Roman amphorae and glass blowing
- D. Iron sickles and silk looms

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "punch-marked coins and guild seals" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.
- **B:** Correct: Spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Roman amphorae and glass blowing" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Iron sickles and silk looms" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.

**Examiner trap 10:** Cotton and spindle whorls belong to production evidence, not later guild records.

### Q11

Consider the following statements:

1. Standard weights and scales support the inference of regular measurement in exchange.
2. Their use proves that Harappans used minted coinage.
3. Weights can be discussed with seals and craft production as parts of an integrated economy.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **C:** Correct: Statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.

**Examiner trap 11:** Weights are evidence of metrology, not minted coinage.

### Q12

Mesopotamian references to Meluhha, Dilmun and Magan are most useful for establishing

- A. that Harappan script has been deciphered in Mesopotamia
- B. that Dilmun was a Harappan capital
- C. that all Harappan trade was controlled by one king
- D. long-distance exchange links, while exact routes, volumes and control remain qualified

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "that Harappan script has been deciphered in Mesopotamia" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "that Dilmun was a Harappan capital" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "that all Harappan trade was controlled by one king" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.
- **D:** Correct: The terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.

**Examiner trap 12:** Meluhha supports contact; it does not disclose one king's trade monopoly.

### Q13

In Mesopotamian textual references, Meluhha is conventionally connected in UPSC preparation with

- A. the Indus/Harappan world or a wider eastern zone
- B. a Harappan name for Dholavira alone
- C. the Vedic kingdom of Kuru
- D. a Roman port on the Red Sea

**Answer: A.**

#### Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a Harappan name for Dholavira alone" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "the Vedic kingdom of Kuru" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a Roman port on the Red Sea" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.

**Examiner trap 13:** Do not shrink Meluhha to one city or equate it with a later kingdom.

### Q14

Which one of the following statements about Harappan script is most accurate?

- A. It is conclusively Brahmi written only left to right.
- B. It is undeciphered; short inscriptions and seal context can be analysed without claiming a translation.
- C. It has yielded a continuous historical chronicle.
- D. It provides king-lists comparable to Mesopotamia.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It is conclusively Brahmi written only left to right." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.

- **B:** Correct: The script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It has yielded a continuous historical chronicle." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "It provides king-lists comparable to Mesopotamia." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.

**Examiner trap 14:** Patterned signs can be studied while the script remains undeciphered.

### Q15

Seals and sealings are most cautiously used by historians to discuss

- A. a complete Harappan epic tradition
- B. a securely known caste code
- C. administrative, ownership-related or transactional practices inferred from context
- D. the personal beliefs of every household

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a complete Harappan epic tradition" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a securely known caste code" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **C:** Correct: Seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "the personal beliefs of every household" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.

**Examiner trap 15:** Seals permit administrative hypotheses, not a recovered caste code.

### Q16

Which one of the following is the safest statement regarding Harappan religious interpretation?

- A. The horned seal figure is securely identified as Shiva.
- B. Fire installations prove a uniform state religion.
- C. Female figurines conclusively prove one Mother Goddess cult.
- D. Figurines, motifs and installations indicate possible ritual practices, but names and doctrines remain unsettled.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "The horned seal figure is securely identified as Shiva." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Fire installations prove a uniform state religion." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.

- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Female figurines conclusively prove one Mother Goddess cult." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.
- **D:** Correct: Material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.

**Examiner trap 16:** Iconography must be described before a later deity-name is proposed.

### Q17

The absence of unambiguous palaces, royal tombs and monumental temples is most relevant to which conclusion?

- A. the exact form of Harappan polity and state religion remains debated
- B. Harappans did not build substantial structures
- C. all settlements were politically independent villages
- D. Harappans had no organised civic life

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: Absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappans did not build substantial structures" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "all settlements were politically independent villages" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappans had no organised civic life" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.

**Examiner trap 17:** Absence of royal tombs limits polity claims; it does not erase organised urban life.

### Q18

Which one of the following best reflects the range of Harappan polity models?

- A. a modern parliamentary federation
- B. centralised state, city-states, or decentralised/corporate elite networks
- C. A known hereditary monarchy only
- D. no social coordination of any kind

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a modern parliamentary federation" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **B:** Correct: The material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "A known hereditary monarchy only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "no social coordination of any kind" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while

standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.

**Examiner trap 18:** Keep several polity models open while identifying the shared coordination evidence.

**Q19**

Consider the following statements about social inference:

1. Variation in house size may suggest unequal access to resources.
2. House size alone proves a fixed caste system.
3. Burial and household evidence require context and comparison before social conclusions are drawn.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **C:** Correct: Variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.

**Examiner trap 19:** House size and grave goods suggest difference but do not directly prove caste.

**Q20**

Which one of the following is least compatible with the current explanation of Harappan decline?

- A. Late Harappan continuities in changed settings
- B. regional variation in change after c. 1900 BCE
- C. interaction of environmental, exchange and internal factors
- D. a single universally proven invasion event that explains every region

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Late Harappan continuities in changed settings" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "regional variation in change after c. 1900 BCE" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "interaction of environmental, exchange and internal factors" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.

- **D:** Correct: The last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.

**Examiner trap 20:** Reject single-event extinction narratives and test regional sequences.

### Q21

The phrase 'de-urbanisation with continuity' is preferred because it

- A. recognises changed urban traits while retaining Late Harappan communities and practices
- B. treats chronology as irrelevant
- C. denies that any urban features changed
- D. means every city remained unchanged after 1900 BCE

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: It captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "treats chronology as irrelevant" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "denies that any urban features changed" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "means every city remained unchanged after 1900 BCE" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.

**Examiner trap 21:** Deurbanisation includes loss and continuity; it is not unchanged city life.

### Q22

Which one of the following is a defensible use of river/environmental evidence in explaining Harappan change?

- A. It proves the identity of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati.
- B. It may be a contributing factor whose relevance must be bounded by region, chronology and other evidence.
- C. It makes trade and internal change irrelevant.
- D. A river shift conclusively explains every Harappan settlement.

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It proves the identity of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **B:** Correct: Environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It makes trade and internal change irrelevant." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "A river shift conclusively explains every Harappan settlement." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.

**Examiner trap 22:** Environmental mechanisms require region, date and a non-environmental comparison.

**Q23**

Consider the following statements regarding Late Harappan developments:

1. Urban traits weakened unevenly after c. 1900 BCE.
2. Regional material traditions became more prominent.
3. Agricultural diversification and settlement shifts are relevant to the phase.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 2 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **C:** Correct: All three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.

**Examiner trap 23:** Late Harappan means localisation with continuing communities, not an empty interval.

**Q24**

Which one of the following site-location statements is correct?

- A. Kalibangan is a coastal site in Gujarat.
- B. Harappa lies on the Indus in Sindh.
- C. Mohenjo-daro lies in the Rann of Kutch.
- D. Rakhigarhi is in Haryana and Dholavira is in Kutch, Gujarat.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Kalibangan is a coastal site in Gujarat." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappa lies on the Indus in Sindh." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Mohenjo-daro lies in the Rann of Kutch." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **D:** Correct: Rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.

**Examiner trap 24:** Rakhigarhi is in Haryana and Dholavira in Kutch; map pairs before features.

**Q25**

Which one of the following correctly describes the Harappan civilisation?

- A. a Bronze Age urban culture with wide regional extent beyond the Indus valley
- B. a literate culture whose script is fully deciphered
- C. an Iron Age culture limited to the middle Ganga plain
- D. a civilisation documented mainly by royal chronicles

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: It is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a literate culture whose script is fully deciphered" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "an Iron Age culture limited to the middle Ganga plain" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a civilisation documented mainly by royal chronicles" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.

**Examiner trap 25:** Harappan is Bronze Age and multi-regional, not Iron Age or Ganga-only.

**Q26**

The Mohenjo-daro Dancing Girl is most directly used in UPSC preparation to identify

- A. a Vedic sacrificial ritual
- B. bronze casting and material culture
- C. iron casting
- D. a royal portrait with known inscription

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a Vedic sacrificial ritual" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **B:** Correct: The figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "iron casting" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a royal portrait with known inscription" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.

**Examiner trap 26:** The named Dancing Girl is bronze; terracotta figurines are a distractor family.

**Q27**

Which one of the following sets contains only Harappan evidence commonly used for specialised production or measurement?

- A. ploughed field, horse stirrup, iron ploughshare

- B. Ashokan pillar, seal of a guild, Roman amphora
- C. bead workshops, spindle whorls, standard weights/scales
- D. Brahmi inscription, punch-marked coin, glass bead

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "ploughed field, horse stirrup, iron ploughshare" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Ashokan pillar, seal of a guild, Roman amphora" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **C:** Correct: Bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Brahmi inscription, punch-marked coin, glass bead" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.

**Examiner trap 27:** Separate Harappan workshop/measurement objects from later coins and inscriptions.

**Q28**

A candidate writes: 'The Harappan citadel proves a centralised monarchy.' Which revision is most evidence-sensitive?

- A. Use the Dancing Girl as proof of monarchy.
- B. Replace 'citadel' with 'temple' and retain the conclusion.
- C. Add that all cities had identical citadels.
- D. State that raised/planned sectors and standardisation indicate coordination, while the form of authority remains debated.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Use the Dancing Girl as proof of monarchy." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Replace 'citadel' with 'temple' and retain the conclusion." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Add that all cities had identical citadels." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **D:** Correct: The revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.

**Examiner trap 28:** Replace 'citadel proves monarchy' with 'raised sector indicates organisation, function debated'.

**Q29**

Which one of the following claims rests on the strongest category of Harappan evidence?

- A. covered drains and wells indicate developed water-related built practice
- B. the horned seal identifies a named deity
- C. a large building proves its use as a state granary
- D. a figurine proves universal female religious authority

**Answer: A.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Correct: Construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "the horned seal identifies a named deity" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "a large building proves its use as a state granary" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a figurine proves universal female religious authority" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.

**Examiner trap 29:** Choose direct built evidence over named-deity or social-system speculation.

**Q30**

For a 150-word answer on Harappan architecture, which sequence is most effective?

- A. religious labels -> a list of every site -> conclusion
- B. planned layout and building technology -> water/drainage -> named regional example -> functional-label caution
- C. one claim about an emperor -> an unqualified verdict
- D. modern conservation news -> dynasty list -> trade route

**Answer: B.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "religious labels -> a list of every site -> conclusion" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **B:** Correct: The second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "one claim about an emperor -> an unqualified verdict" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "modern conservation news -> dynasty list -> trade route" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.

**Examiner trap 30:** A 150-word architecture answer needs regional variation and label caution, not a site dump.

**Q31**

Consider the following statements:

1. Lothal is useful for bead-working and a basin conventionally identified as a dockyard.
2. Dholavira is useful for reservoirs and a large signboard.
3. Kalibangan is useful for a ploughed-field association.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 2 only

**Answer: C.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.
- **C:** Correct: All three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 2 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.

**Examiner trap 31:** Lothal basin, Dholavira signboard and Kalibangan plough marks must stay distinct.

**Q32**

Which one of the following statements best distinguishes an observation from an inference?

- A. 'The script is translated' is observation, whereas a seal is an inference.
- B. 'The Harappans used drainage' is an inference, whereas 'they had an emperor' is observation.
- C. 'Mother Goddess' is a material observation, whereas a figurine is speculation.
- D. 'A seal carries a horned figure' is observation; identifying it as Pashupati is an interpretation.

**Answer: D.**

**Option-wise explanation:**

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "'The script is translated' is observation, whereas a seal is an inference." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "'The Harappans used drainage' is an inference, whereas 'they had an emperor' is observation." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "'Mother Goddess' is a material observation, whereas a figurine is speculation." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **D:** Correct: The image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.

**Examiner trap 32:** Observation is the object or context; Pashupati, palace and empire are interpretations.

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### VERIFIED ROUTED PYQS AND KEY DISCIPLINE

### PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2019, GS-I, Q7

**Question:** Which one of the following is not a Harappan site?

- A. Chanhudaro
- B. Kot Diji
- C. Sohgauna
- D. Desalpur

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: C. Sohgauna.**

Chanhudaro is a Harappan craft town, Kot Diji has Early and Mature Harappan levels, and Desalpur is a fortified Harappan site in Kutch. Sohgauna in Uttar Pradesh is associated with a later copper-plate inscription. The local official question paper is verified; the matching official answer key is unavailable locally, so the answer is not labelled official.

**PYQ trap:** A famous archaeological name is not automatically Harappan; classify period, region and assemblage.

### PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims 2021, GS-I, Q32

**Question:** Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into connected reservoirs?

- A. Dholavira
- B. Kalibangan
- C. Rakhigarhi
- D. Ropar

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. Dholavira.**

Dholavira used dams, channels and connected reservoirs in the seasonal Manhar-Mansar setting. Kalibangan is associated especially with a ploughed surface and fire installations; Rakhigarhi with a large Haryana urban complex; Ropar with a long cultural sequence. The official question is locally verified, but the corresponding official key is unavailable.

**PYQ trap:** Do not generalise all Harappan water systems from Dholavira; this question asks for the reservoir-dam complex.

### PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims 2025, GS-I, Q72

**Question:** The famous female figurine known as 'Dancing Girl', found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of

- A. carnelian
- B. clay
- C. bronze
- D. gold

**OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCAL SET-A KEY: C. bronze.**

The named figurine is a small bronze produced through lost-wax casting. Terracotta female figurines make clay a plausible distractor, but they are different objects. The locally held official 2025 Set-A key records C for Q72.

**PYQ trap:** Match the named object, not the broader material category of Harappan figurines.

### PYQ 4 - UPSC Prelims 2026, GS-I, Q8

**Question:** Consider the following statements about archaeological findings in Harappan towns:

I. There is wide occurrence of spindle-whorls in houses but absence of spinning wheels. II. Weights and measurement scales, complete with graduations, have been discovered. III. Houses were built in large part with baked bricks around relatively spacious courtyards, with their own wells, bathing platforms and large rooms.

Which inferences can be drawn?

1. Statement I suggests that spinning was a laborious activity done at home.
  2. Statement II suggests the extent of scientific knowledge possessed by the Harappans.
  3. Statement III suggests the emergence of a common property system.
- A. 1 and 2 only
  - B. 2 and 3 only
  - C. 1 and 3 only
  - D. 1, 2 and 3

**INFERRED ANSWER - PROVISIONAL KEY, NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. 1 and 2 only.**

Household spindle-whorls support domestic manual spinning, and graduated weights/scales support developed measurement. House plans and private wells do not establish a legal common-property system. The locally held key is provisional; this solution remains explicitly inferred.

**PYQ trap:** An artefact can support an activity inference without proving a legal property regime.

## PYQ 5 - UPSC Mains 2025, GS-I, Q1

**Question:** Discuss the salient features of the Harappan architecture. (Answer in 150 words.)

**Demand:** "Discuss" requires defining features, named examples, regional variation and a bounded conclusion.

**Model answer:** Harappan architecture combined civic coordination with regional adaptation. Planned streets, side-lane entrances and courtyard houses created ordered residential blocks. At Mohenjo-daro, wells, bathing floors and covered drains connected households to shared sanitation; the waterproof Great Bath demonstrates specialised collective construction. Standard mud and baked bricks, commonly using a 1:2:4 proportion in the Mature phase, enabled modular building. Yet plans varied: Dholavira used stone, multiple enclosed sectors and reservoirs adapted to seasonal streams, while Kalibangan had different wastewater arrangements. Lothal's brick basin and Harappa's large storage-related buildings indicate specialised functions, but labels such as "dockyard", "granary" and "citadel" remain archaeological interpretations. Thus Harappan architecture was planned, water-conscious and technically standardised, but regionally diverse and textually anonymous.

**Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive with construction, domestic form, water, public works, four named sites, variation and source criticism within the required limit.

## SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

### ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

**Question:** Explain how Dholavira modifies the conventional picture of Harappan town planning. (Answer in 150 words.)

**Model answer (102 words):**

Dholavira modifies the conventional model by showing that Harappan cities did not follow one Indus-core plan. Located on Khadir island in Kutch, it used extensive stone construction, several enclosed sectors and a large signboard rather than a simple universal citadel-lower-town division. Dams and channels drew seasonal water from the Manhar-Mansar setting into reservoirs and cisterns, making water storage part of the city's spatial design. These features demonstrate shared Harappan capacities for planning, measurement and public labour, but also strong regional adaptation to material and hydrological conditions. Dholavira therefore supports coordinated diversity: it belongs firmly to Mature Harappan urbanism while disproving architectural uniformity.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It directly contrasts a common template with precise Dholavira evidence and ends with a qualified civilisational inference.

### ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

**Question:** Why must religious interpretations of Harappan objects remain cautious? (Answer in 150 words.)

**Model answer (108 words):**

Harappan religion is reconstructed without a deciphered text. The horned seated figure, varied female figurines, pipal and animal motifs, fire installations, burials and the Great Bath can indicate symbolic or ritual practices. However, names such as Pashupati and Mother Goddess project later categories onto objects whose contemporary meanings are unknown. Fire features may be domestic, industrial or ritual, and a waterproof public bath does not by itself reveal doctrine. A sound interpretation therefore separates observation from inference: describe form, context and repetition; compare alternatives; then state confidence. The evidence supports ritual diversity, but not a securely named pantheon, uniform state religion or unbroken continuity with later Hindu practice.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It uses named evidence, explains the source problem and provides an executable inference rule.

### ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

**Question:** Analyse the relationship between Harappan cities, rural production, craft specialisation and labour. (Answer in 250 words.)

**Model answer (151 words):**

Harappan urbanism functioned through an interdependent settlement hierarchy. Villages, farms and pastoral zones supplied grain, fibre, livestock and labour; quarry, mining and coastal zones supplied stone, metals and shell. Cities and specialist centres converted these inputs into beads, seals, faience, textiles, pottery and copper-bronze objects. Chanhudaro demonstrates concentrated craft without a conventional citadel, while Lothal links workshops, measurement and a large basin to exchange. Shortugai shows procurement reach toward highland mineral corridors.

Standard weights, repeated seal forms and transport by carts, river craft and coastal routes made dispersed production comparable and movable. Public works at Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira also required brick-making, construction and recurring maintenance labour.

Yet archaeology cannot identify the legal status of workers or the exact balance among household production, attached specialists, market exchange and redistribution. The evidence therefore supports organised, differentiated labour within a connected urban-rural economy, not a self-sufficient city or a fully reconstructed state labour code.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It connects settlement levels through flows of material and labour, uses three distinct sites and qualifies institutional reconstruction.

### ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

**Question:** Does Harappan standardisation prove a centralised empire? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

**Model answer (151 words):**

Standardised weights, seals, brick proportions and aspects of urban planning show remarkable integration across the Mature Harappan world. Cubical weights enabled comparable quantities; common seal practices supported communication or transactions; modular bricks aided construction; and major water works indicate organised labour. Such regularity makes sustained coordination undeniable.

It does not, however, identify the political mechanism. Dholavira's stone-built multi-sector plan, Kalibangan's distinct drainage and Chanhudaro's specialist form show regional variation within the shared system. More importantly, the undeciphered script has yielded no secure king-list, dynasty or administrative constitution, while no unambiguous palace, royal tomb or monumental temple identifies a ruling house.

Three models therefore remain open: a centralised state, several regional states or city-states, and corporate or decentralised elites linked by shared institutions and exchange. Standardisation is evidence of capacity and norm enforcement, but not a signature unique to empire. The most defensible verdict is strong civilisational coordination with unresolved political form.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It weighs the positive evidence for authority against the missing discriminators and evaluates competing models.

### ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

**Question:** Critically examine the decline of Harappan urbanism as a multi-causal regional transformation. (Answer in 250 words.)

**Model answer (187 words):**

After about 1900 BCE, the integrated urban system weakened unevenly rather than disappearing in one catastrophe. Large cities contracted or were abandoned; script, seals, long-distance standards and some specialised crafts declined; settlement patterns and pottery traditions became more regional.

Several mechanisms may have interacted. River movement and recurrent flooding affected particular settlements; weakening monsoons or aridity raised agricultural and water risk; changes in Gulf-Mesopotamian exchange reduced some external demand; and internal political-economic reorganisation may have undermined institutions that coordinated labour and circulation. None explains every region. A palaeoclimate proxy has a scale and date, and the Ghaggar-Hakra/Sarasvati identification is separate from demonstrating its effect on a settlement. The invasion model also lacks evidence for one conquering event that destroyed the civilisation.

The Late Harappan record supplies the necessary qualification. Communities continued in smaller or shifted settlements, agriculture diversified, and selected pottery, craft and subsistence practices persisted, even as cities, writing and integrated standards diminished.

Thus "decline" means regionally varied deurbanisation and localisation: major institutional discontinuity combined with demographic and cultural continuity. A good explanation connects cause, local mechanism, chronology and response instead of listing universal theories.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It is genuinely critical: it tests each cause, states scale limits, explains outcomes and reconciles discontinuity with continuity.

## ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

**Question:** Evaluate what archaeology and scientific evidence can-and cannot-tell us about Harappan society and legacy. (Answer in 250 words.)

**Model answer (199 words):**

Archaeology reconstructs Harappan life most securely through material practices. Houses, drains and reservoirs reveal construction and maintenance; crop, animal and residue evidence reconstruct diet; workshops and provenance identify production and exchange; burials and skeletal study illuminate mortuary treatment, health and mobility. Radiocarbon dating refines chronology, while isotopes and ancient DNA can test bounded questions about movement and ancestry.

These methods also impose limits. Unequal houses or grave goods may indicate differentiated access, but do not directly prove caste, slavery or a complete class hierarchy. Figurines and seals may preserve ritual imagery, but cannot name deities while the script remains undeciphered. The published Rakhigarhi genome concerns one context-specific individual; it cannot identify the language, religion or total ancestry of every Harappan population. Environmental proxies likewise require regional and chronological matching.

Legacy should therefore be divided into continuity and discontinuity. Crops, craft knowledge, rural settlement and some symbols or practices may continue through regional interaction, while urban scale, script, seals and integrated standardisation clearly declined.

Scientific evidence makes Harappan history more precise by narrowing claims, not by authorising total identities. The defensible legacy is selective continuity through transformed communities, not an unchanged civilisation or a biological verdict on language and culture.

**Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check:** The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

**Why this earns marks:** It distinguishes methods by question, uses concrete evidence, states sample limits and gives a balanced legacy conclusion.

## OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

This block is enrichment. It is not required for a competent core answer.

### ADVANCED 1 - HISTORIOGRAPHY OF STATE AND URBANISM

Older empire, priest-king and invasion models often treated monumental sectors as direct institutions. Later household, craft, landscape and political-economy approaches allow several authority models. Use the historiography to explain why the evidence can establish integration more securely than a specific constitution.

### ADVANCED 2 - HOUSEHOLD AND CRAFT ARCHAEOLOGY

Activity areas, production debris, access routes and house modification can recover work below the level of the city plan. They sharpen questions about household production and specialised labour, but a workshop does not automatically identify a guild, caste or state factory.

### ADVANCED 3 - SCRIPT-METHOD DEBATES

Sign frequency, positional pattern, direction, medium and seal context remain legitimate subjects of analysis. Estimates of the number of signs depend on how variants are counted. No proposed language or decipherment has achieved secure acceptance; avoid presenting computational pattern as translation.

### ADVANCED 4 - ARCHAEOOMETRY AND PROVENANCE

Petrography, elemental analysis and experimental archaeology can distinguish material sources and production sequences. Their answer value lies in connecting a finished object to procurement and technique. A chemical match establishes material movement more directly than it establishes the identity or political status of the mover.

### ADVANCED 5 - PALAEOCLIMATE, RIVERS AND SCALE

Lake, speleothem, sediment and channel studies can indicate changing hydrology or monsoon conditions. Every proxy has spatial resolution, chronological uncertainty and a mechanism problem. It must be connected to the occupation history of the relevant site; it cannot settle the textual Sarasvati question by itself.

### ADVANCED 6 - GENETICS AND BIOARCHAEOLOGY

The 2019 Rakhigarhi ancient-DNA result is important but sample-bounded. Ancient DNA, isotopes, skeletal pathology and dental evidence can address ancestry, mobility, diet and health only within preservation and sampling limits. Language, religion, polity and the complete history of a civilisation cannot be read from one individual.

### ADVANCED 7 - EGYPT AND MESOPOTAMIA: A BOUNDED COMPARISON

Egypt and Mesopotamia offer readable royal or administrative texts and conspicuous royal/temple monuments. Harappan evidence foregrounds civic water, settlement and standardisation without securely identified kings or monumental temples. This contrast concerns surviving evidence and institutional display; it is not a ranking of complexity or proof that Harappans lacked authority.

## CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

### 1. NAME, PHASES AND EVIDENCE

- Harappan is safer than a literal Indus Valley label; Bronze Age, protohistoric and archaeologically reconstructed.
- Early c. 3300-2600 BCE -> Mature c. 2600-1900 BCE -> Late c. 1900-1300 BCE, regionally variable.
- Process terms: regionalisation -> integration -> localisation/deurbanisation.
- Script undeciphered: practice can be reconstructed more securely than rulers, language or doctrine.

## 2. DISCOVERY AND MAP

- Cunningham noticed a seal (1853); Daya Ram Sahni excavated Harappa (1921); R. D. Banerji worked at Mohenjo-daro; John Marshall announced the civilisation.
- Extent anchors: Sutkagen-dor west, Manda north, Alamgirpur east, Malvan south; Shortugai is an Afghanistan outpost.
- Ghaggar-Hakra palaeochannel evidence and textual Sarasvati identification must not be collapsed.

## 3. SITE-FEATURE GRID

| Site         | Fast recall                                           | Caution                         |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Harappa      | Ravi, R-37, working platforms, 12-unit building       | "Granary" qualified             |
| Mohenjo-daro | Great Bath, wells/drains, bronze Dancing Girl         | "Priest-King" unknown           |
| Dholavira    | Khadir, stone, reservoirs, signboard, multi-part plan | Not universal template          |
| Rakhigarhi   | Haryana, large inland centre, craft/cemetery          | One-genome limit                |
| Kalibangan   | ploughed field, fire installations                    | Not automatically Vedic         |
| Lothal       | bead/copper craft, basin                              | "Dockyard" qualified            |
| Banawali     | sequence, moat/fortification, plough model            | Distinctive regional plan       |
| Chanhudaro   | unfortified craft town                                | No conventional citadel         |
| Surkotada    | fortified Kutch site, disputed equid                  | Horse not characteristic        |
| Shortugai    | mineral-route outpost                                 | Not automatic imperial province |

## 4. URBANISM, WATER AND LABOUR

- Settlement ladder: farms/herds/resources -> villages -> specialist centres -> towns -> cities.
- Brick norms, streets and courtyards show common grammar; Dholavira and Kalibangan prove regional variation.
- Wells, bathing floors, drains and reservoirs imply recurring maintenance and labour.
- Coordination is secure; monarch, council or corporate mechanism remains debated.

## 5. ECONOMY AND MATERIAL CULTURE

- Crops: wheat/barley; regional millets/rice; pulses/oilseeds; cotton. Cattle prominent; horse rare/disputed.
- Crafts: beads, shell, faience, pottery, textiles and copper/bronze; no iron-centred Mature system.
- Graded weights/scales support measurement; no minted Harappan coinage.
- Internal food/material movement underpinned cities; Meluhha-Dilmun-Magan support external contact with bounded route/control claims.

## 6. SCRIPT, SOCIETY, POLITY AND RELIGION

- Short inscriptions, often right-to-left; several hundred signs depending on variant count; language unknown.
- House, craft and burial variation -> differentiation; not automatic caste, slavery or matriarchy.
- Polity models: central state, regional states/city-states, corporate elites.
- Pashupati, Mother Goddess, fire altar, Great Bath ritual and granary/dockyard labels remain interpretations.

## 7. DECLINE, CONTINUITY AND SCIENCE

- After c. 1900 BCE: uneven city contraction, settlement shift, reduced script/seals/standards and stronger regional traditions.
- Cause families: river/flood, aridity, exchange contraction and internal reorganisation; none universal alone.
- Late Harappan communities, agriculture and selected material practices continued.
- Scientific rule: method -> sample/context -> result -> representativeness -> bounded inference.

## 8. UPSC TRAPS AND ANSWER ROUTES

- 2019: non-Harappan site Sohagaura - inferred, official local key unavailable.
- 2021: Dholavira water system - inferred, official local key unavailable.
- 2025: Dancing Girl bronze - official local Set-A key.
- 2026: statements 1 and 2 - inferred; local key provisional.
- 2025 Mains architecture: plan -> construction -> water -> public works -> regional variation -> label caution.
- Universal answer formula: define -> phase/map -> named evidence -> analysis -> alternative/limit -> qualified verdict.

## 9. OPTIONAL ADVANCED - USE SELECTIVELY

- Add one refinement only when useful: household archaeology, polity historiography, script methods, provenance, palaeoclimate scale, genetics limits or bounded Egypt/Mesopotamia comparison.
- Never let advanced science overrule context or convert a sample into language, religion or total population identity.